African players on his BlackBerry. He would later admit in his autobiography to agreeing in one exchange that Strauss was behaving like a ‘doos’, a colloquial Afrikaans insult for ‘dick’ or ‘idiot’.

He had laughed along with us at the ‘KPgenius’ parody account on Twitter, lampooning public perceptions of his character in the build-up to Headingley. Suddenly he seized on it as evidence of poor faith from his teammates. It transpired the account was owned by a friend of Stuart Broad, but he and Graeme Swann, who was also implicated, swore on their lives they weren’t involved.

As so often happens in these situations, views became polarized. The debate generated more heat than light. Had KP initially been more transparent and shared his phone records as soon as the investigation was instituted, a lot of problems could have been avoided. As it was, what would be Straussy’s farewell to Test cricket was overshadowed by rancour and suspicion.

A week after that match at Lord’s I was in Southampton, killing time before a day–nighter against the South Africans. I never slept late, so was watching *Homes Under the Hammer* in T-shirt, shorts and flip-flops, when Andy Flower called. ‘Where are you?’ he asked. ‘I need to see you.’ His manner was bland, as if he was working through a final pre-match checklist.

I twigged what had happened when I walked into the downstairs meeting room and saw him sitting with Hugh Morris of the ECB. They clearly weren’t interested in small talk about Dion Dublin’s vision for a semi-detached in Sidcup, but it’s funny how big decisions, and huge career milestones, seem so matter-of-fact.

Flower wasted no time: ‘Straussy is resigning the captaincy and is going to announce his retirement from the game tomorrow,’ he said. ‘I would like you to become the new England Test captain. Will you do the job?’

‘Absolutely,’ I replied. ‘I’d love to. It’s a huge honour.’

And that was that, a schoolboy fantasy reduced to a statement of the obvious. I turned to leave the room and paused before opening the door when Flower added: ‘Don’t tell anyone, and don’t let it distract you from the game tonight. You’ve got a big game.’

‘Oh, I won’t,’ I promised. ‘Don’t worry, I’ll be on it.’

Of course, I got 0, bowled second ball by Lonwabo Tsotsobe, who would go on to become a DJ after being banned for eight years in a match-fixing